

What Must I Do to Be Saved?

The Gospel of Jesus Christ According to Scripture

The question “*What must I do to be saved?*” is the most important question a human being can ever ask. It concerns not merely this present life, but our eternal destiny.

It is also a question Scripture answers clearly.

Salvation is not found in religious achievement, moral goodness, human wisdom, or sincere belief in whatever spiritual path a person chooses. Salvation is found in a Person—Jesus Christ.

Jesus Himself declared:

“I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.” — John 14:6

That statement leaves no room for another way to God.

Jesus did not say that He was *one way* among many. He said He is *the way*. He did not say He possessed *a truth*. He said He is *the truth*. And He did not merely offer *a way of life*. He said He is *the life*.

Therefore, if someone teaches that salvation can be found apart from Jesus Christ, that teaching cannot be reconciled with the words of Christ Himself.

Buddha cannot save.

Muhammad cannot save.

No pope can save.

No priest, pastor, rabbi, imam, religious leader, philosophy, or system of good works can save.

And no one can save himself.

The issue is not whether these people or religions may contain teachings that appear moral or spiritually meaningful. The issue is much more fundamental:

Can they reconcile a sinful person to the holy God?

According to Scripture, only Jesus Christ can do that.

Peter declared:

“Salvation exists in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given to men by which we must be saved.” — Acts 4:12

The gospel is therefore not a message about improving ourselves.

It is the message of what God has done for us through His Son.

1. We Are All Sinners

The place to begin is not with what we think about ourselves, but with what God says about us.

Scripture declares:

“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.” — Romans 3:23

Every human being stands guilty before God.

The problem is not merely that some people have made more mistakes than others. The problem is sin itself.

God is holy, and His standard is perfect righteousness.

Paul writes:

“There is no one righteous, not even one.” — Romans 3:10

No amount of comparison with other people can change that.

We may consider ourselves good people because we have tried to live morally, helped others, given money to charity, attended church, or followed religious practices.

But none of those things removes our guilt before God.

2. We Cannot Save Ourselves

The next truth is equally important.

We cannot solve the problem of sin through our own efforts.

Paul writes:

“For no one will be justified in His sight by works of the law.” — Romans 3:20

The law reveals our sin; it does not provide the means by which we can erase it.

Good works cannot cancel bad works.

Religion cannot remove guilt.

Sincerity cannot transform sin into righteousness.

Turning over a new leaf cannot erase the past.

We need something we cannot provide for ourselves.

We need a Savior.

3. God Did What We Could Never Do

This is where the gospel changes everything.

God did not leave humanity without hope.

He sent His Son.

Paul writes:

“But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” — Romans 5:8

The cross was not an accident.

It was God's provision for our sin.

Jesus Christ, the sinless Son of God, willingly took our place and bore the judgment our sin deserved.

Isaiah had foretold:

“But He was pierced for our transgressions, He was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was upon Him, and by His stripes we are healed.” — Isaiah 53:5

At Calvary, Jesus accomplished what no human being could accomplish.

He paid the debt.

He bore the judgment.

He satisfied the demands of divine justice.

And then, from the cross, Jesus cried:

“It is finished!” — John 19:30

Those words were not the cry of defeat.

They were the declaration of completion and victory.

The work He came to accomplish was finished.

4. Jesus Christ Alone Is the Way of Salvation

This is the point at which the gospel stands apart from every religious system based upon human effort.

Jesus did not merely teach people how to find God.

Jesus is the way to God.

He declared:

“I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.” — John 14:6

There is therefore no second path to the Father.

Not Buddha.

Not Muhammad.

Not religious observance.

Not human morality.

Not good works.

Not church membership.

Not religious authority.

Not sincerity.

Christ alone.

Scripture gives a solemn warning against any message that presents another way of salvation:

“But even if we or an angel from heaven should preach a gospel contrary to the one we preached to you, let him be under a curse!” — Galatians 1:8

Paul repeats the warning:

“As we have said before, so now again I say: If anyone is preaching to you a gospel contrary to the one you received, let him be under a curse!” — Galatians 1:9

The issue is therefore not simply that people may have different religious opinions. The issue is **the gospel itself**. There is one gospel of salvation, centered upon the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Any teaching that offers another way of salvation is not another version of the gospel. It is a different gospel.

Paul summarized the gospel this way:

“For there is one God and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus.” — 1 Timothy 2:5

There is one God.

There is one Mediator.

There is one Savior.

Jesus Christ.

Anyone—including a pope, priest, pastor, religious teacher, philosopher, or spiritual leader—who teaches that a person can come to God through another way is teaching something contrary to the testimony of Scripture. **It is a “false gospel.”**

5. Jesus Rose from the Dead

The cross was not the end.

Jesus Christ rose from the dead.

Paul writes that Christ *“was delivered over to death for our trespasses and was raised to life for our justification.”* — Romans 4:25

The resurrection demonstrates that death could not hold Him.

The One who died for our sins lives again.

Christianity therefore does not rest merely upon the teachings of a dead religious leader.

It rests upon the risen Christ.

Paul explains the central message of the gospel:

“For what I received I passed on to you as of first importance: that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that He was buried, that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures.” — 1 Corinthians 15:3–4

The gospel is not *try harder*.

The gospel is **Christ has done what you could never do.**

6. Salvation Is Received by Faith

If Christ has accomplished the work of salvation, what must we do?

Believe.

Paul tells us:

“If you confess with your mouth, ‘Jesus is Lord,’ and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved.” — Romans 10:9

And:

“Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.” — Romans 10:13

Salvation is not something we earn.

It is something we receive.

Paul writes:

“For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God—not by works, so that no one can boast.” — Ephesians 2:8–9

The sinner's response is therefore not to attempt to pay God back.

It is to trust the One who has already paid the price.

7. God Has Done the Work

This is one of the most beautiful truths of the gospel.

God did not ask us to climb our way up to Him. **He came down to us.** He sent His Son, who lived the sinless life we could not live, died the death we deserved, bore our sins, and rose from the grave.

And from the cross, Christ declared:

“It is finished.”

The work of redemption was accomplished.

Our salvation therefore rests not upon the strength of our commitment to Christ, but upon the finished work of Christ for us.

That is grace.

8. The Holy Spirit Seals the Believer

God does not merely save us; He also seals us with His Holy Spirit.

Paul writes:

“And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, in whom you were sealed for the day of redemption.”
— Ephesians 4:30

And again:

“And having believed, you were marked in Him with a seal, the promised Holy Spirit.” —
Ephesians 1:13

The Holy Spirit is God's seal upon the believer.

Our salvation rests upon God's promise, God's work, and God's faithfulness.

This does not give the believer permission to live carelessly or continue deliberately in sin. Grace changes the direction of a person's life.

But our confidence is not ultimately in ourselves.

It is in Christ.

9. What About Good Works?

Good works matter—but they are the result of salvation, not the means of obtaining it.

Paul writes:

“For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life.” — Ephesians 2:10

Notice the order.

We are saved *by grace through faith*.

Then we are created in Christ Jesus *for good works*.

Good works do not purchase salvation.

They demonstrate the reality of a transformed life.

We do not obey God in order to become His children.

We obey because, through Christ, He has made us His children.

10. God Is the One Who Seeks the Lost

Many people speak about *seeking God*.

But the gospel reveals something even more remarkable:

God seeks sinners.

Jesus said:

“For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost.” — Luke 19:10

God has already taken the initiative.

He sent His Son.

He provided the sacrifice.

He raised Him from the dead.

He sends the gospel into the world.

And He calls sinners to repent and believe.

The question is therefore not whether God is willing to receive the person who comes to Him through Christ.

He has already demonstrated His willingness at the cross.

The question is:

Will you trust Jesus Christ?

11. What Must I Do to Be Saved?

The question was once asked directly:

“What must I do to be saved?” — Acts 16:30

The answer was equally direct:

“Believe in the Lord Jesus and you will be saved.” — Acts 16:31

That is the gospel.

You do not need to become good enough first.

You do not need to clean yourself up before coming to Christ.

You do not need to earn God's acceptance.

Come to Christ as you are.

Confess your sin.

Turn to Him.

Trust Him.

Believe that He died for your sins and rose again.

Trust Him alone.

The promise of Scripture is clear:

“Therefore, since we have been justified through faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.” — Romans 5:1

And Jesus promised:

“Truly, truly, I tell you, whoever hears My word and believes Him who sent Me has eternal life and will not come under judgment. Indeed, he has crossed over from death to life.” — John 5:24

A Simple Prayer of Faith

If you understand the gospel and sincerely desire to place your trust in Jesus Christ, you can express your faith to God in words like these:

Heavenly Father,

I know that I am a sinner and that I cannot save myself. I confess my sin and turn from trusting in my own goodness, religion, or works.

I believe that Jesus Christ is Your Son, that He died on the cross to pay for my sins, that He was buried, and that You raised Him from the dead.

I place my trust in Jesus Christ alone as my Lord and Savior.

Thank You for forgiving my sins and giving me eternal life—not because of anything I have done, but because of Your grace through Jesus Christ.

Help me to follow You, grow in Your Word, and live for Your glory.

In Jesus' name, Amen.

Your New Life in Christ

This prayer does not save you.

Jesus Christ saves you.

The prayer is simply an expression of the faith you have placed in Him.

Salvation is not found in a formula, a repeated prayer, or a religious ceremony.

Salvation is found in Jesus Christ.

“For everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.” — Romans 10:13

If you have trusted Jesus Christ as your Lord and Savior, your new life in Christ has begun. One of your first steps of obedience should be to follow Christ in baptism.

Baptism does not save you, nor does it add anything to the finished work of Christ. We are saved by grace through faith. Baptism is an outward testimony of the inward faith you have placed in Christ and an act of obedience to His command.

After His resurrection, Jesus gave His disciples the Great Commission:

“Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit.” — Matthew 28:19

Baptism was therefore not presented as merely an optional religious ceremony, but as part of the believer's first steps of obedience to Christ.

The book of Acts repeatedly shows those who believed the gospel responding with baptism. Having trusted Christ, the new believer should therefore seek to be baptized and begin walking openly as a follower of Jesus.

Baptism does not make you a Christian.

Christ does.

Baptism is your public identification with the One who saved you.

Begin reading the Gospel of John. Talk with God in prayer. Study His Word. And find a Bible-believing church where you can grow in your new life in Christ.

The gospel can be stated simply:

I am a sinner.

I cannot save myself.

Jesus died for my sins.

Jesus rose from the dead.

Jesus alone is the way to the Father.

Salvation is God's gift, received by faith in Christ alone.

And the invitation remains open:

“Believe in the Lord Jesus and you will be saved.” — Acts 16:31